Rouzhi Liang

rouzhil@smu.edu · Personal Website
3300 Dyer Street, Dallas, TX 75275
Latest version available here

Academic Appointments

Postdoctoral Researcher, Southern Methodist University *2026 - Present*

Education

Ph.D. in Economics, Southern Methodist University *2026*
M.A. in Economics, Southern Methodist University *2022*
M.S. in Economics, University of Wisconsin-Madison *2018*
B.A. in Economics, Beihang University *2016*

Research Fields and Interests

Fields: Macroeconomics, Economic Growth, International Trade
Interests: Intergenerational Inequality, Entrepreneurship, Culture

Working Papers

Bequests, Fertility, and Barriers to Entrepreneurship: The Intergenerational Transmission of Economic Inequality *(Job Market Paper)* (PDF)
*** Winner of the SEA 2024 Graduate Student Award**

This paper studies how endogenous fertility and bequest decisions shape the intergenerational transmission of entrepreneurship and inequality in the presence of financial frictions. I develop and quantify an overlapping-generations model in which parents jointly choose fertility and bequests, while children make occupational choices subject to borrowing constraints given the bequest they receive. The model is calibrated to match evidence from the US PSID on family structure, wealth, income, and entrepreneurship. Eliminating financial frictions raises steady-state income per capita by 13 percent but reduces the entrepreneurship rate and increases income inequality. Improved credit access reallocates capital toward more productive firms, allowing them to expand while inducing less productive entrepreneurs to become workers. Their expansion raises the equilibrium return on capital, disproportionately benefiting wealthier households because they hold substantially more financial wealth.

Individualism, Innovation and Economic Development: Evidence from Cross-Country and Within-U.S. Analyses (PDF)

This paper examines the impact of individualism on innovation and economic development over time, both across countries and within the US. At the country level, I extend the literature by expanding the time scope and incorporating more controls while employing instrumental variables. However, results vary across specifications. Then I turn to the within-US analysis and construct time-varying individualism measures at the county group level using ancestry ratios and country-level individualism indexes. Contrary to the existing literature, I find that individualism has a negative or insignificant influence on innovation and economic development. These findings raise new questions about how cultural traits may interact with institutions.

Service Trade and Multinational Activities *(Draft available upon request)*
with Jun Nie, Michael Sposi, and Jing Zhang

Research in Progress

Finance, Demographic Transition, and Structural Change

Multiple Entrepreneurial Talent Misallocation joint with Javier Gonzalez

Culture, Mobility, and Economic Growth joint with Ömer Özak and Chih Ming Tan

Research Experience

Graduate Research Assistant for Dr. Wookun Kim *2020*
- Collected and cleaned NASA satellite-based pollution data using Python and QGIS
- Built geospatial datasets for empirical research in environmental economics
- Demonstrated ability in remote sensing and spatial data visualization

Graduate Research Assistant for Dr. Michael Sposi *2022*
- Collected global trade datasets and analyzed the data using Stata
- Strengthened skills in data cleaning and macroeconomic analysis

Graduate Research Assistant for Dr. Daniel L. Millimet *2024*
- Cleaned Census data and replicated county-level trade shock data
- Demonstrated proficiency in managing complex datasets and multiple projects

Graduate Research Assistant for Dr. Lones Smith and Dr. Lorenzo Magnolfi *2018-2019*
- Use expected loss as price for lottery to estimate the supply and demand curve.
- Work on the lotteries of Mega Ball and China's 7 Lucky Lottery.

Teaching Experience

Southern Methodist University

Instructor: Intermediate Macroeconomics *Summer 2023*

Teaching Assistant:

Macroeconomic Theory I (Ph.D.-level)	*Fall 2023*
Microeconomic Theory I (Ph.D.-level)	*Fall 2021*
Microeconomic Theory II (Ph.D.-level)	*Spring 2021*
Strategic Behavior (Master-level)	*Fall 2019; Spring 2020; Spring 2021*
Economic Analysis I (Master-level)	*Fall 2019*
Economic Analysis II (Master-level)	*Spring 2020*
International Macroeconomic Theory and Policy (Undergraduate-level)	*Spring 2020; Spring 2023*
Intermediate Microeconomics (Undergraduate-level)	*Spring 2020*

Conference and Seminar Presentations

- **Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting** *2025*
  Bequests, Fertility, and Barriers to Entrepreneurship
  Individualism and Innovation: Unraveling Culture's Influence Across Time
- **North Texas Economics Conference** *2025*
  Bequests, Fertility, and Barriers to Entrepreneurship
- **Three Minute Thesis Competition Finalist** *2025*
  Bequests, Fertility, and Barriers to Entrepreneurship
- **Southern Methodist University Brown Bag Seminar** *2025*
  Bequests, Fertility, and Barriers to Entrepreneurship
- **Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting** *2024*
  Bequests, Fertility, and Barriers to Entrepreneurship (Graduate Student Award)
- **Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting** *2023*
  Individualism and Innovation: Unraveling Culture's Influence Across Time
- **SMU Research and Innovation Week** *2023*
  Bequests, Fertility, and Barriers to Entrepreneurship (Poster Presentation)

Skills

Programming Python, Stata, QGIS, LaTeX
Language English (Fluent), Mandarin (Native)

Fellowships & Awards

Provost's Doctoral Candidacy Fellowship, Southern Methodist University *2023–2026*
Graduate Student Award, Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting *2024*
Graduate Fellowship, Southern Methodist University *2019–2023*

Leadership & Outreach

SMU Department of Economics, Ph.D. Peer Mentor *2022–2024*
SMU Dedman Graduate Student Assembly, Representative for the Economics Department *2023–2025*
SMU Dedman Graduate Student Assembly, President *2025–2026*
Moody School Graduate Student Advisory Member from Dedman College *2025–2026*

References

Dr. Ömer Özak (PhD Advisor)
Associate Professor of Economics, Southern Methodist University
Email: ozak@smu.edu

Dr. Michael Sposi (Postdoc Supervisor & PhD Committee)
Associate Professor and Director of Doctoral Studies, Southern Methodist University
Email: msposi@smu.edu

Dr. Rocío Madera (PhD Committee)
Assistant Professor of Economics, Southern Methodist University
Email: romadera@smu.edu